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Look Nearer East

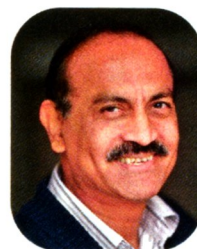
Even as India's foreign policy makers focus on how to deal with Pakistan after the Mumbai attacks, they would be wise not to neglect the major political changes that have either been effected or are taking place in other parts of the neighbourhood. In Nepal, India needs to help efforts to stabilise the nascent democratic forces led by former Maoist guerrilla leader Prachanda. In Sri Lanka, President Mahinda Rajapakse's Government has scored major victories in the war against the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE) and New Delhi must work towards getting Colombo to come out with a credible devolution package for the Tamils if peace is to prevail. As significant is the big change in Bangladesh where Sheikh Hasina Wajed has been voted to power with a massive mandate. While India has engaged both Sri Lanka and Nepal on pressing issues, it should start preparing for a major diplomatic initiative with Bangladesh which would both strengthen Hasina's Government and also ensure New Delhi's long-term interests. The recent elections saw a massive mandate against corruption, high-handedness and inefficiency of Begum Khaleda Zia's chaotic rule. Importantly, the electorate also voted out attempts by her party, the Bangladesh Nationalist Party, to form an electoral alliance with Islamic fundamentalists, including the Jamaat-e-Islami. Also those who tried to raise the old bogey of an Indian threat didn't receive much support.

There are critical issues that confront Hasina and her main focus would obviously be the economy. Though Bangladesh's economy has been growing at around 6 per cent annually—healthy by current standards—there is a massive need to boost infrastructure facilities. This includes constructing a major bridge across the river Padma, which divides the south-west areas of Bangladesh from the rest of the country, upgrading railway networks and ensuring food security. India could lend a helping hand

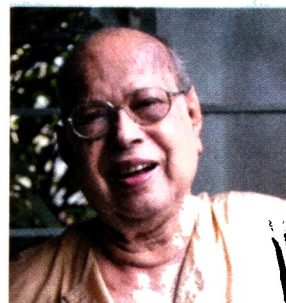
SAURABH SINGH



and do something to correct the trade imbalances that Bangladesh faces in its relations with its larger neighbour. While India exports goods and services worth around \$3.5 billion annually to Bangladesh, its imports total just \$350 million and there is a need to address such a discrepancy. Meanwhile, India should begin working with Hasina's Government on its security interests such as managing the border, settling outstanding territorial disputes and working out ways to check migration. India also needs to push for cooperation in dealing with terrorism and preventing Bangladesh's territory from being used by the North-east extremists as a safe haven or to stage attacks. But it needs to give time to Hasina, who has always been favourably disposed towards India, to settle down and assist in building up her comfort zones. Winning over Bangladesh would be a major foreign policy achievement.



DIED: Filmmaker **Tapan Sinha**, 84. He won the Dadasaheb Phalke award and is best known for his films like

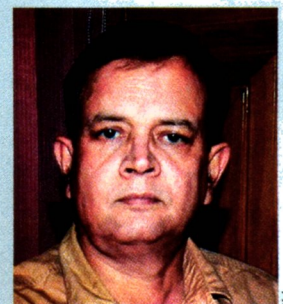


Kabuliwala, Ek Doctor Ki Maut and Wheel Chair.

DELHI NEEDS TO GIVE TIME TO HASINA, WHO HAS ALWAYS BEEN FAVOURABLY DISPOSED TOWARDS INDIA, TO SETTLE DOWN AND ASSIST IN BUILDING HER COMFORT ZONES.

DIED: Former CPI(M) Politburo member and former CITU president **E. Balanandan**, 84. He had been a member of the Lok Sabha, Rajya Sabha and the Kerala Legislative Assembly.

APPOINTED: Radha Vinod Raju, special director-general of police in Jammu and Kashmir, as director-general of



the National Investigation Agency

AWARDED: To writer and scholar **Dr Hari Narayan Dikshit**, the Vachaspati Puraskar for 2008, by the K.K. Birla Foundation for outstanding Sanskrit work published in the past 10 years.